lousy at baseball that when our group was choosing up sides for a game, I was always the last kid chosen.

I remember one time when I was in the eighth grade. I was playing second base and a ball was hit straight toward me but I didn't realize it. Everybody was looking at me, expecting me to catch it. I just stood there. The ball landed behind me and everybody said, "Oh, no!"

I hadn't seen it. I didn't know about the ball coming toward me until I heard it drop on the ground. You don't forget things like that.

I didn't know then that there was a reason for my problems. As a result, I had a lot of trouble convincing myself I was good enough to play with the other kids, a deficiency of confidence that's not a small matter when you're growing up in a youthful world dominated by sports and games. I was always the first to think: *I can't make the team. I'm not as good as Jack or Jim or Bill*.

My troubles in sports, along with always having been the new kid in school, left me with some insecurities. I suppose it isn't unusual for schoolchildren to suffer feelings of inferiority and lack of self-confidence—I'd be surprised if it wasn't one of the most common afflictions of childhood—but when it's happening to you, it can seem the biggest thing in the world, and for a while it caused me a lot of heartache.

In a town like Dixon during the early 1920s, the silent movie was still a novelty, "talkies" hadn't been invented yet, visits by vaudeville troupes were still rare, and television was something you read about in science fiction stories. People had to rely on themselves for entertainment, and at this, my mother excelled.

She was the star performer of a group in Dixon that staged what we called "readings": Dixonites would memorize dramatic or humorous passages from famous poems, plays, speeches, or books and deliver them in a dramatic fashion before an audience at church or elsewhere.